lack of support from the Congress. Following that, he was made a Rajya Sabha member (2002–2008) by the NDA government. Not only had he managed to get out of a sticky situation unscathed, he had also endeared himself to two prime ministers from two opposing parties, Indira Gandhi and later Atal Bihari Vajpayee.

I have had no direct access to or interaction with Alexander. Therefore, my assessment of his role in Punjab affairs is essentially based on the contents of his book and references to his role by other authors. In his memoirs, *Through the Corridors of Power: An Inside Story* , Alexander devoted one full chapter of ninety-two pages to the 'Akali Agitation'. In it he has mentioned that there were twenty-six rounds of talks with the Akalis between October 1981 and May 1984, to seek a solution through peaceful negotiations. [3] Surprisingly, he has not mentioned a single word about the most important round of these negotiations, the one mediated by Swaran Singh, which Alexander attended. [4] On the other hand, Alexander gives very minute details in his book of the Rajiv Gandhi-led talks, which followed within a fortnight of the sabotage of the Swaran Singh-led talks on the night of 3-4 November, 1982. In that context, the following paragraph from Alexander's book is rather interesting:

> As one who knew Indira Gandhi's thought process well and as one who participated in all the talks, I can assert on the basis of direct knowledge, that she sincerely believed till the last minute that a solution could be found through talks and, therefore, wanted to avoid use of force. There have been some highly mischievous reports that Indira Gandhi had initiated these talks and kept their momentum only to create the impression of seeking a settlement through negotiations but that she had always planned to crack down on the Akalis. Nothing could be farther from the truth. [5]

Alexander says Indira Gandhi 'sincerely believed till the last moment that a solution could be found through talks'. In fact, there was no need to stretch the negotiations till 'the last moment' in the first place as she could have settled the matter back in 1982 by